

FEDERAL LAUNCH KIT · SAM.GOV REGISTRATION

Pick the NAICS codes that **win** set-asides.

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THE FOUR-TOOL SYSTEM

FREE · LETTER PDF

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A LETTER TO THE OPERATOR

Most firms pick three codes and wonder why **nothing** matches.

I built CapturePilot because we kept seeing the same pattern. A firm registers in SAM, picks the two or three NAICS codes that feel obvious, and then waits for set-aside opportunities that never appear. Six months in, they assume federal contracting is closed to them.

It isn't closed. Their NAICS list is too short. Agencies search by NAICS. If you aren't listed under the code a contracting officer types into SAM, you are invisible. Five-to-ten codes is the working range. Some firms carry fifteen.

This picker is the worksheet I wish we'd had. Seven steps to build the list. Fifteen high-spend codes with the FY25 dollar figures. A self-assessment so you don't certify under a size standard you can't actually meet.

Run it before you finalize your SAM rep. Re-run it every twelve months — your services change, your revenue changes, the size standards change.

A. Schuler

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<https://meetings-na2.hubspot.com/american/intro-call>

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Pick the codes the way contracting officers **actually** search.

Your NAICS codes in SAM.gov do two jobs. They decide which set-aside contracts you qualify for, and they decide what size standard the SBA applies to you. Pick the wrong primary and you end up 'large' on the contracts you wanted, 'small' on contracts you can't deliver.

The next pages cover the seven-step selection method, then the fifteen NAICS codes with the highest federal spend in FY25 so you know which ones are worth fighting for.

PART ONE • METHODOLOGY

Seven steps from services list to SAM-ready NAICS short list.

Your NAICS codes in SAM.gov determine which set-aside contracts you qualify for and what your small-business size standard is. Choose strategically. Don't pick from memory.

- 01 List every service or product your company delivers.** Not just what you do today — include what you're capable of performing with current staff and equipment.
- 02 Look up each service on [census.gov/naics](https://www.census.gov/naics).** Use the keyword search to find candidate codes. Write down every match, even close ones.
- 03 Check the size standard for each code at [sba.gov/size-standards](https://www.sba.gov/size-standards).** The standard is either revenue-based (\$X million averaged over five years) or employee-based.
- 04 Confirm you qualify as 'small'** under the size standard for each candidate code. If you don't, drop the code or note it for later.
- 05 Prioritize codes where federal spending is significant.** Check [usaspending.gov](https://www.usaspending.gov) by NAICS — a code with \$50M in annual spend is a different conversation than one with \$500M.
- 06 Select your primary NAICS** — the one that best represents your core business. This is what agencies use to classify your proposals and what shows in most SAM searches.
- 07 Add 5–10 secondary NAICS codes.** More codes equals more opportunities to appear in searches. Cap it at what you can credibly perform — overreach gets you removed for cause.

FIELD TIP

Run this every twelve months. Size standards update. Your revenue changes. The services you can credibly perform shift as you hire. A NAICS list you set during SAM registration in year one is wrong by year three.

PART ONE • MARKET REFERENCE

Top 15 federal NAICS codes by sector.

Federal obligations in FY25, ranked by total spend with the SBA size standard you'll certify against. Use this to weight your list — a code with \$12B in spend deserves more attention than one with \$1B.

NAICS	DESCRIPTION	SIZE STANDARD	FY25 FED SPEND
541512	Computer Systems Design Services	\$34M revenue	\$12.4B
541511	Custom Computer Programming	\$34M revenue	\$8.9B
541519	Other Computer Services	\$34M revenue	\$6.1B
541330	Engineering Services	\$25.5M revenue	\$9.2B
236220	Commercial & Institutional Building Construction	\$45M revenue	\$7.8B
561210	Facilities Support Services	\$47M revenue	\$6.4B
541611	Management Consulting	\$24.5M revenue	\$5.1B
562910	Remediation Services	\$25.5M revenue	\$3.8B
611430	Professional & Mgmt Development Training	\$16.5M revenue	\$2.9B
336414	Guided Missile & Space Vehicle Mfg	1,250 employees	\$18.2B
621111	Offices of Physicians (except Mental Health)	\$16.5M revenue	\$1.4B
561320	Temporary Staffing Agencies	\$34M revenue	\$4.7B
561110	Office Administrative Services	\$34M revenue	\$2.1B
518210	Data Processing, Hosting	\$34M revenue	\$3.6B
511210	Software Publishers	\$34M revenue	\$5.3B

HOW TO READ THIS

FY25 spend numbers come from USASpending.gov rollups across all federal agencies. A code with \$12B in spend doesn't mean you'll see \$12B in opportunities — most of that is awarded to large primes. But it tells you the addressable market is real. Codes under \$1B in annual spend are niche; treat them as secondary.

PART ONE • INTERPRETATION

Three things the spend table doesn't say out loud.

The fifteen codes above are the starting point, not the answer. Three patterns are worth pulling out before you build your own list.

Revenue-based vs. employee-based

Most codes use revenue, averaged over your last five completed fiscal years. A few — manufacturing, aerospace, defense supply — use employee count. 336414 (Guided Missile & Space Vehicle Mfg) is 1,250 employees, not dollars. If you're a 30-person engineering shop that does some integration work, you might be 'small' under both 541330 and 336414 — but the certification math is different for each.

The IT cluster is one market with three doors

541511, 541512, and 541519 together account for over \$27B in FY25 spend. Most IT services firms qualify for all three. Pick the one closest to your core delivery as primary, then add the other two as secondary. Same size standard (\$34M revenue), same buyers, three more ways to show up in agency searches.

Facilities and remediation are quieter, set-aside heavier

561210 (Facilities Support), 562910 (Remediation), and 561720 (Janitorial) don't crack the top of the spend list, but a much higher percentage of those dollars goes through small-business set-asides. If you can credibly perform in these areas, the win rate per opportunity is usually better than chasing IT integration prime awards.

FIELD TIP

Don't pick a primary based on what pays best. Pick it based on what you've actually delivered in the last twenty-four months with documented past performance. A primary you can't defend on a CPARS reference will hurt you in evaluations.

Score yourself against the codes **before** you certify.

The next two pages are the working sheet. Five sectors. Twenty-plus codes. Check every code your company can credibly perform — meaning you have the staff, the equipment, and at least one piece of past performance you'd hand to an evaluator.

If you can't check a box honestly, don't put the code in SAM. The set-aside opportunities you'd see are the same ones that get you removed for cause when you can't deliver.

PART TWO • WORKING SHEET

NAICS code self-assessment.

For each service area below, check every code your company can credibly perform. Honest check means: you have the staff, the equipment, and at least one piece of past performance you can defend.

Information Technology & Cybersecurity

- ☒ ☐ **541512** — Systems Integration
- ☒ ☐ **541511** — Custom Software Development
- ☒ ☐ **541519** — IT Support / Help Desk / NOC
- ☒ ☐ **518210** — Cloud / Hosting / Data Center
- ☒ ☐ **511210** — Software as a Service (SaaS)

Engineering & Technical

- ☒ ☐ **541330** — Civil / Structural / Mechanical Engineering
- ☒ ☐ **541310** — Architectural Services
- ☒ ☐ **541350** — Building Inspection Services
- ☒ ☐ **541360** — Geophysical Surveying / Mapping
- ☒ ☐ **541380** — Testing Laboratories

Construction & Facilities

- ☒ ☐ **236220** — Commercial / Institutional Construction
- ☒ ☐ **237310** — Highway / Street / Bridge Construction
- ☒ ☐ **561210** — Facilities Support / O&M
- ☒ ☐ **561720** — Janitorial Services
- ☒ ☐ **562910** — Remediation / Environmental Cleanup

PART TWO • WORKING SHEET (CONTINUED)

Professional, staffing, and the size-standard trap.

Professional Services

- ☒ ☐ **541611** — Management Consulting
- ☒ ☐ **541612** — HR Consulting
- ☒ ☐ **541613** — Marketing Consulting
- ☒ ☐ **541990** — Other Professional Services
- ☒ ☐ **611430** — Training & Education

Staffing & Administrative

- ☒ ☐ **561320** — Temporary Staffing
- ☒ ☐ **561110** — Office Administrative Services
- ☒ ☐ **561410** — Document Preparation
- ☒ ☐ **561720** — Clerical Staffing

SIZE STANDARD TRAP

You can be 'small' under one NAICS and 'large' under another. A 40-person consulting firm at \$26M revenue is small under 541330 (\$25.5M — barely over, watch the five-year average), large under 541611 (\$24.5M), and small under 541512 (\$34M). The certification math is per-code.

Always verify at the SBA size standards tool before you certify. A wrong rep is a False Claims Act exposure, not just a paperwork error.

Once your boxes are checked

Count your checks. If you have more than ten honest checks, narrow to the eight or nine you can defend with the strongest past performance. If you have fewer than three, your services list is probably too narrow — re-read step one of the methodology and add anything you've delivered commercially that could translate to federal.

PART TWO • NEXT STEPS

Turn the worksheet into a SAM.gov registration that wins.

You have a primary NAICS, five-to-ten secondary codes, and a size-standard check for each. Three things to do before you hit submit in SAM.

1. Verify each size standard, one more time

Pull the current SBA size standards table at [sba.gov/size-standards](https://www.sba.gov/size-standards). The standards update — what was \$30M last year is \$34M now for several IT codes. Use your five-year revenue average, not last year's number. If you're within 10% of the threshold on your primary, document the calculation in a file you can hand to a contracting officer if challenged.

2. Put the right code as primary

Your primary NAICS shows in most SAM exports and agency dashboards. Pick the code that matches the work you're actually selling — not the one with the highest spend, not the one with the most generous size standard. If a contracting officer pulls your record while screening for a sources sought, the primary is what they read first.

3. Document why you picked each secondary

Keep a one-page internal note: for each NAICS in your SAM record, list one piece of past performance, one capability statement reference, and the size-standard math. When you renew SAM next year and someone on your team asks 'why do we have 561720 in here,' the answer is on file.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Once the codes are in, set a recurring calendar reminder for ninety days before SAM renewal. Re-run this worksheet. Drop codes you didn't bid under. Add codes you've grown into. The list is a living document, not a one-time decision.

WHAT'S NEXT

Stop guessing which codes pay. **Score** them.

CapturePilot pulls your NAICS list, scores each code against live federal opportunities, and tells you which secondary codes are actually generating matches. Free 14-day trial. No card.

Get the full Federal Launch Kit

[HTTPS://WWW.CAPTUREPILOT.COM/STARTUP-PACK](https://www.capturepilot.com/startup-pack)